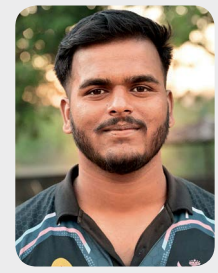
and focus on reading to enhance his professional and technical knowledge. Then there is Komal Misal, a housewife, who says she has started trying out new recipes at home thanks to the time off from TV serials.

Inspired by such outcomes, other villages in the region, such as Vahagaon and Chachegaon in Satara, Peth Vadgaon and Talsande in Kolhapur, and the Madha town in Solapur, have started following the detox model or are on their way to do so. Already, says sarpanch Mohite, he has received calls from many other village representatives. Vishwajeet Kadam, former minister and Congress MLA from Palus-Kadegaon in Sangli, in whose constituency Mohityanche Vadgaon falls, says they are trying to promote the initiative further. "We are promoting it in the two talukas (in the constituency)... I hope this initiative catches on," he says.

That shouldn't be difficult. The digital detox programme also aligns with the Sangli district council's ongoing project: it has been developing model schools in every village of the district and aims to involve parents in the education of their children. Jitendra Dudi, chief executive officer (CEO) of the Sangli zilla parishad, says that they held a conference of representatives from all villages to inform them about the initiative. So far, around seven villages in Sangli district have adopted this regimen, and more are expected to join in. "The intention is to help parents focus on the education of their children."

The results are also beginning to show in other villages that have adopted the programme, and it won't be surprising if such a digital detox becomes a way of life. Sangram Adhikrao Pawar, the sarpanch of Vahagaon village in Satara's Karad taluka, says, "We first conducted a survey in the village to assess if we should go ahead with the plan. We were wary about how women would respond, since they usually watch television at that time, but they were receptive to the idea to ensure that their children could get a brighter future." The results in Vahagaon, which has around 5,000 residents and started the digital detox regimen on October 12 last year, are telling. Anandi Dilip Pawar, a gram panchayat member and mother of two, says that her daughter, who studies in Class 8, has secured a scholarship because she was able to focus on studies, thanks to the television being switched off. Likewise, another resident, Sujata Pujari, says her son Kanishka, who recently appeared for his Class 12 examinations, has been able to study better. Then there's Ranjana Pawar, who says that she has now taken to reading books instead of watching TV. And while Harshavarshan Nalawade, a Class 4 student, says that he managed to stand first in his class, his sister Shreya (Class 8) says that she can understand subjects better now. The daily arguments over the TV remote have also come to an end, she adds laughingly. All this reflects in the classroom too: Mangesh Tate, a teacher at the local secondary school, notes that he has seen a marked improvement in the handwriting of his students. Elsewhere in Kolhapur's Talsande village, Shivaji Patil, the former deputy sarpanch, says that he has started reading more since he went on the digital detox. "Senior citizens in our village have gone back to reading books, a habit that had almost died out due to television," he says.

Back in Mohityanche Vadgaon, the siren is ringing again. It's 8.30 pm and the end of the digital curfew. But Rida Mujawar, only in Class I, continues to study, refusing to even have dinner till she completes her lessons. It's a different kind of addiction, and a welcome one. ■



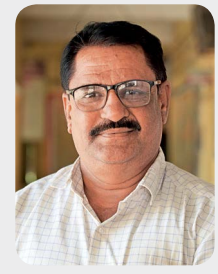
"PEOPLE SPEAK TO EACH OTHER MORE NOW, THERE'S A SENSE OF BELONGING. EARLIER, LIFE REVOLVED AROUND TV SHOWS"

Abhijit Mohite, 23, resident of Mohityanche Vadgaon village, Sangli district



"THE DIGITAL DETOX HELPED WHEN MY SON KANISHKA WAS IN CLASS 12. HE COULD STUDY BETTER"

Sujata Pujari, 40, resident of Vahagaon village, Satara district



"STUDENTS NOW STUDY ON THEIR OWN INITIATIVE. THE SCHOOL, ON A WHOLE, HAS SEEN QUALITATIVE IMPROVEMENT"

M.A. Mane, 53, principal, Vidyarthi Vikas Vidyalaya High School, Mohityanche Vadgaon